

Body image

A person becomes more aware of their body image during the teenage years when their appearance may start to become more important to their sense of identity. If a teen is unhappy about how they look, it can affect their confidence and self-esteem.

Explaining body image

Body image is how a person perceives how they look, as well as the thoughts and feelings associated with this perception. These feelings can be positive, negative, or a bit of both. How people perceive their body doesn't necessarily equate to how they really look.

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Body image is not about how teens look, but how they feel about how they look.

Influencing body image

Puberty can be a turbulent time for a tween or teen and their body image. Throughout adolescence, some young people feel constantly self-conscious. In addition to the physical transformations experienced during puberty, other things can affect body image:

Media manipulation

Teens are introduced to unrealistic “ideal” body shapes or standards of beauty through celebrity culture and digitally manipulated images in the media. The pressure to conform to these standards can lead teens to adopt unhealthy behaviors, such as dieting.

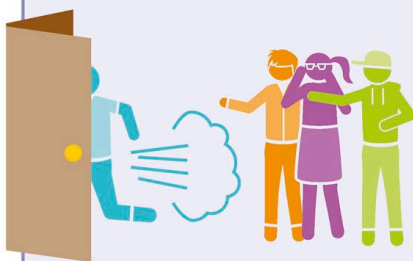


△ False “perfection”

It is important to remember that images in the media are typically altered to give a false impression of “perfection.”

Body shaming

Body shaming is when people criticize the appearance of others or themselves directly, through gossip, online, or in person. It is a type of bullying that involves making people feel bad about the way they look, and can directly result in poor body image and low self-esteem.



△ Teasing

Even for outwardly confident teens, hurtful comments about their appearance can be humiliating and upsetting.

Difficult life events

Facing any kind of upheaval, such as moving to a new school or going through a breakup, can make teens feel vulnerable about how they look. Teens might become very self-critical as a way of channeling stress and coping with a challenging situation.



△ Upheaval

Encountering people in new situations can also cause a teen to worry about how they are perceived.